

# 13

## Backup, File Recovery and Restore Requests

Deleted or overwritten files, previous versions, mailbox and system restores

**Default priority:** P3 Medium  
(P2 if business-critical data is lost)

**Target response / resolution:** Respond in 30 min / restore in 4 business hours

**Handled by:** Tier 2, then Infrastructure

### Scope

Use this instruction when a user needs to recover a deleted, overwritten, or corrupted file, folder, or mailbox item, or when a system or server restore is requested.

**Related instructions:** WI-10 Security Incidents, WI-09 Access Requests, WI-05 Email and Calendar

### Common symptoms

- File or folder deleted by mistake
- A document was saved over with the wrong content
- File is corrupted and will not open
- Mailbox items missing after a clean-up
- A restore of a server or a database is requested

### Information to collect

- Full path or location of the file, and its exact name
- Date and time it was last known to be correct
- How it was lost (deleted, overwritten, corrupted, ransomware suspected)
- Who owns the data, and how urgent the need is

### Resolution steps

- 1 Check the easy options first.** Look in the Recycle Bin, the cloud storage recycle bin, and the Deleted Items or Recoverable Items folder. Most losses are recovered here without a restore.
- 2 Try version history.** In OneDrive, SharePoint, or the file server's Previous Versions, open the history and restore the last good version. Confirm with the user before replacing the current file.
- 3 Confirm what is needed.** If the data is not in these places, confirm the exact item, location, and point in time. A precise request saves time and avoids restoring the wrong data.
- 4 Get approval where required.** Restores of shared or sensitive data need approval from the data owner. A restore of a system needs a change record and approval from the service owner.
- 5 Run the restore to a safe location.** Restore to an alternative location first, never directly over the live data. Check the restored copy with the user before moving it back.
- 6 Check for wider problems.** If many files have changed or been renamed at once, or extensions look unusual, stop and treat it as a possible ransomware event (see WI-10).
- 7 Confirm and record.** Ask the user to open the file and confirm that the content is correct. Record the restore point, the source backup, and the time it took.

#### Escalate when

- Backup job failed or the required restore point does not exist
- Large restores, server restores, or database restores
- Signs of ransomware, mass deletion, or malicious activity

#### Resolution and closure

- Record the item, the restore point used, and who approved it
- Advise the user how to use version history in the future
- Close after the user confirms the restored data is correct

## Quick troubleshooting reference

| Symptom                           | Likely cause                                | What to do                                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| File deleted from a network share | Accidental deletion                         | Check Previous Versions or the backup system, restore to a temporary folder, and move back after user confirmation. |
| Document overwritten              | Saved over by mistake                       | Use version history to restore the earlier version. Download it rather than replace the current one.                |
| File will not open (corrupted)    | Interrupted save, disk fault, or sync issue | Try a previous version or the backup copy. Check the disk and sync client for errors.                               |
| Mailbox items missing             | Deleted by rule or manual clean-up          | Search Recoverable Items, then use the mailbox recovery tool within the retention period.                           |
| Many files renamed or unreadable  | Possible ransomware                         | Disconnect the device, do not restore yet, and raise a security incident immediately.                               |

## Suggested wording for the user

|               |                                                                                                                                             |
|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Open</b>   | <i>"I will try to recover that for you. Can you tell me where the file was saved and when you last saw it in good condition?"</i>           |
| <b>During</b> | <i>"I found a version from yesterday afternoon. I will restore it to a separate folder so you can check it before we replace anything."</i> |
| <b>Close</b>  | <i>"Your file is back. In future, you can right-click the file and choose version history to get an earlier copy yourself."</i>             |

## Good practice

### Do

- Restore to a temporary location first
- Ask for the exact time and path
- Check the data owner's approval for shared data
- Document the restore point used

### Do not

- Do not restore over live data without a check
- Do not promise recovery before you check what backups exist
- Do not restore after suspected ransomware until Security agrees
- Do not forget the retention limits, as old data may be gone

## Worked example

A project manager deleted a folder of contracts from the shared drive on Monday and reports it on Wednesday.

| Ticket note field       | Entry                                                                                        |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Issue reported</b>   | Folder 'Contracts 2026' missing from the Legal share since Monday.                           |
| <b>Checks performed</b> | Not in the recycle bin. Previous Versions has a snapshot from Monday 07:00.                  |
| <b>Cause</b>            | Accidental deletion by a user with delete permission.                                        |
| <b>Action taken</b>     | Owner approved. Restored the folder to a temporary location, user verified, then moved back. |
| <b>Result</b>           | All 46 files recovered. Permissions reviewed to reduce delete rights.                        |

## Frequently asked questions

### Q. How long do we keep backups?

Retention depends on the service and policy. Publish the retention table in the knowledge base so analysts can quickly say whether a restore is possible.

### Q. The user wants a restore of the whole shared drive to last week. Can we do it?

That is a large restore with risk of overwriting other people's work. Escalate to Infrastructure, get owner approval, and prefer restoring only the needed folders.

**Q. Can users restore their own files?**

Yes, from the recycle bin and version history. Teaching this reduces tickets and speeds up recovery.

**Analyst checklist**

- |                                                             |                                                                            |
|-------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> Check the easy options first       | <input type="checkbox"/> Check for wider problems                          |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Try version history                | <input type="checkbox"/> Confirm and record                                |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Confirm what is needed             | <input type="checkbox"/> Ticket note completed using the standard template |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Get approval where required        | <input type="checkbox"/> User confirmed the issue is resolved              |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Run the restore to a safe location |                                                                            |

**Preventing repeat tickets**

- Teach users to use version history and the recycle bin
- Test restores every quarter
- Review delete permissions on shared folders
- Keep retention periods documented and published